

Jose Ibarra

STAFF SOFTWARE ENGINEER

Denver, CO

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I'm the engineer leaders turn to when change feels risky or a team's path forward is unclear - sometimes by setting strategy, sometimes by writing the migration myself. In complex domains like payroll, tax, and rewards, I translate product vision into the platform boundaries, APIs, and technical strategy that let multi-team organizations ship.

Work Experience

Bonusly

Denver, CO

STAFF SOFTWARE ENGINEER

Apr. 2024 - Present

- Generated \$2M in increased yearly redemptions by introducing physical rewards to the Bonusly catalog. Collapsed data models and introduced simpler design patterns that made the system significantly easier to extend.
- Drove 40% customer adoption of group giving by tech-leading the team that launched the feature for recognition.
- Unlocked a new customer segment by spearheading the team that closed product gaps to ship the Achieve subscription tier.
- Cut average PR review time by several hours and eliminated 10+ hours/month of manual dependency work by leading developer experience initiatives across the entire 20-engineer org: standardized linting configs, automated dependency upgrades, and built code ownership tooling.
- Coached first-time tech leads to on-time project delivery and authored the team's design patterns and coding principles guide, establishing shared standards across the engineering org.

Gusto

Denver, CO

SENIOR STAFF & STAFF SOFTWARE ENGINEER

Jan. 2022 - Apr. 2024

- Designed and shipped a new payroll platform API consumed by 3 downstream teams, enabling parallel development of a new mobile app, spreadsheet import flow, and modernized web payroll experience without requiring changes to the core payroll engine.
- Led the extraction of a major payroll service from the monolith to unlock a new revenue stream. Delivered a migration plan and proof of concept that enabled the company to evaluate the opportunity.
- Authored and drove adoption of the FY2024 technical strategy for the Payroll Services org (40 engineers across 5 teams), aligning roadmaps around improved service boundaries and informing the technical direction for FY2024 planning.
- Mentored 6 engineers across junior to senior levels (3 promoted) and spread deep knowledge of the payroll system's internals across teams.

Gusto

Denver, CO

SENIOR SOFTWARE ENGINEER

Nov. 2018 - Dec. 2021

- Delivered \$1B+ in COVID tax credits to 10%+ of US employers by building out the credit issuance system during the pandemic relief effort.
- Led the refactor of the federal and state 1099 system to support filing new 1099-NEC specification for 300,000+ filings for the 2020 tax year.
- Tech lead of a team that introduced improvements to the run payroll frontend including displaying payroll input totals, revamping payroll error display, and revamping the display of payroll calendars. Drove down preventable errors in the run payroll flow by 99%, removed unactionable errors for 4.4% customers, and increased user throughput through the critical flow.
- Led an effort to improve our on-call workload through process and coding improvements for a group of 30 engineers.
- Anchored the work to reduce production console access for team by establishing processes and building new operational tools. Reduced all console access by 87% and write-enabled console access by 83% for the team.
- Conducted 100+ interviews while Gusto was scaling up the engineering team. Served on the hiring excellence committee to improve interviewing standards, developing new interview questions and rubrics to consistently evaluate candidates.

Skills & Strengths

Domains	Payroll, tax, and payments systems; rewards and incentive platforms; high-stakes financial systems processing billions in transactions
Architecture	API design and platform engineering; monolith decomposition; designing service boundaries for multi-team consumption; data model simplification and refactoring
Leadership	Org-wide technical strategy; mentoring and developing engineers (junior through senior); interviewing and hiring
DevEx	On-call process design; dependency management automation; developer experience tooling; reducing operational toil at org scale
Tech	Ruby, Java, JavaScript/TypeScript, SQL · Rails, React · MySQL, PostgreSQL, MongoDB · AWS, Docker

Education

Arizona State University

M.C.S. IN COMPUTER SCIENCE

Tempe, AZ

Jan. 2015 – Aug. 2018

- GPA: 3.70

Arizona State University

B.S. HONORS DIPLOMA IN COMPUTER SCIENCE

Tempe, AZ

Aug. 2010 – May 2014

- GPA: 3.78, CS GPA: 4.0, Magna Cum Laude
- Honors Thesis: Visual Analytic Tools for Geo-Genealogy and Geo-Demographics